CHAPTER 2 The Tool: The Reversal of Desire The Higher Force: The Force of Forward Motion

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Subject	**CHAPTER 2 The Tool: The Reversal of Desire The Higher Force: The Force of Forward Motion**
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Internal

THE COMFORT ZONE

Avoiding pain wouldn't be a problem if we did it once or twice a year. But for most of us, it's a deeply ingrained habit. We barricade ourselves behind an invisible wall and don't venture out because beyond the wall is pain. This safe space is called the "Comfort Zone." In the most extreme cases, people hide behind the actual walls of their home, afraid to venture into the outside world. That's what it means to be agoraphobic. But for most of us, the Comfort Zone isn't a physical place; it's a way of life that avoids anything that might be painful.

Try the following exercise (all exercises are best done with your eyes closed):

Pick something you hate doing. It could be traveling, meeting new people, family gatherings, etc. How do you organize your life so you can avoid doing it? Imagine that pattern is a place you hide in. That's your Comfort Zone. What does it feel like?

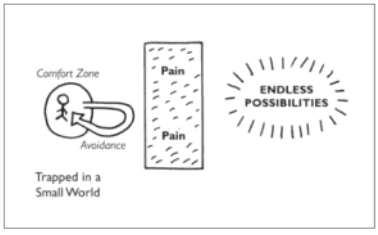
You probably felt you were in a safe and familiar place, free of the pain the world brings with it. This almost completely re-creates your Comfort Zone, but it leaves out the final ingredient. Strange as it might seem, merely escaping pain isn't enough for us. We insist that the pain be replaced with pleasure. We do this with an endless array of addictive activities: Internet surfing, drugs and alcohol, pornography, the aptly named "comfort food." Even manic gambling and shopping are pleasures of a sort. All these behaviors are widespread—we're an entire culture looking for its Comfort Zone. We weave these activities into our daily routines.

Ask yourself what your own warm-bath activities are. The more frequently you indulge in them, the more likely it is that you're using them to create a Comfort Zone. Now try the following exercise:

Feel yourself indulging in one or more of these behaviors. Imagine the pleasure you feel lifts you into a womb-like world. How does this world affect your sense of purpose?

Whatever your Comfort Zone consists of, you pay a huge price for it. Life provides endless possibilities, but along with them comes pain. If you can't tolerate pain, you can't be fully alive. *The Comfort Zone is supposed to keep your life safe, but what it really does is keep your life small.*

Here's a way to picture the Comfort Zone and the price you pay for living in it:



Most of us are like the stick figure, stuck inside the Comfort Zone. To take advantage of the endless possibilities that life provides us, we have to venture out. The first thing we meet is pain. Without a way to get through it, we scurry back to safety. This is depicted in the arrow that goes out, comes close to pain, and turns back again. Eventually, we give up on ever escaping the Comfort Zone; our most treasured dreams and aspirations are lost. Nineteenth-century physician, teacher, and author Oliver Wendell Holmes in "The Voiceless" wrote: "Alas for those that never sing, / But die with all their music in them."

It is a tragedy to die with your song unsung. What's worse is that *we* are guilty of stilling our own voices—*we silence ourselves*. Yet despite the terrible price we pay, we don't leave the Comfort Zone. Why not?

Because we're held there by the classic modern weakness: the need for immediate gratification. The Comfort Zone makes us feel good in the moment. Who cares what the future penalty will be? But the penalty does come, bringing with it the worst pain of all—the knowledge that you've wasted your life. We're trained as a society to expect, even demand, immediate gratification. And we have an extraordinary ability to rationalize this weakness. Instead of admitting we're avoiding pain, we tell ourselves we're being virtuous. We end up with a distorted worldview that makes avoidance seem right, even brave and idealistic. This is the worst sin of all—lying to ourselves. It makes change impossible.

THE HIGHER FORCE: FORWARD MOTION

A few rare individuals refuse to live limited lives. They drive through tremendous amounts of pain—from rejections and failures to shorter moments of embarrassment and anxiety. They also handle the small, tedious pain required for personal discipline, forcing themselves to do things we all know we should do but don't—like exercising, eating right, and staying organized. Because they avoid nothing, they can pursue their highest aspirations. They seem more alive than the rest of us. They have something that gives them the strength to endure pain—a sense of purpose. What they do in the present, no matter how painful, has meaning in terms of what they want for the future. The avoider only cares about immediate gratification; he takes no responsibility for his future. A sense of purpose doesn't come from thinking about it. It comes from taking action that moves you toward the future. The moment you do this, you activate a force more powerful than the desire to avoid pain. We call this the "Force of Forward Motion." The Force of Forward Motion only works in an individual if she consciously chooses to use it—and accepts the pain that comes with it. Most of us choose avoidance instead. As a result, we don't live up to our potential, never becoming fully ourselves.

The tools were designed to take advantage of the unusual nature of higher forces. We're used to forces we can control: we step on the gas, switch on the light, turn on the hot water, and get the response we want. These forces are separate from us, we control them from the outside. It doesn't matter what state we're in ourselves. That won't work with higher forces; they're not subject to outside control. To harness a higher force, you have to become one with it. You do that by taking on the same form the force takes—making yourself into a miniversion of it. No amount of thinking can do this for you; you need to change your state of being.

THE TOOL: THE REVERSAL OF DESIRE

We've chosen to make the Force of Forward Motion the first higher force we discussed because its nature is the most obvious, moving relentlessly through the universe with a sense of purpose. To tap into this force, *you* need to move relentlessly forward in your own life—only then have you taken on its form. But doing that is not so easy. By now, you know we avoid the pain of forward motion at all costs. Phil seemed undaunted by this nasty human weakness. He told me—with complete confidence—that anyone could master their fear of pain. I asked him what made him so certain. He replied that he'd discovered a tool that trained you to *desire pain*.

The tool is called the "Reversal of Desire." Before you try it, pick a situation you're avoiding. It needn't involve physical pain. More likely, you're avoiding some kind of emotional pain; a phone call you're putting off, a project that seems overwhelming, or a task that's simply tedious.

Once you've chosen a situation, imagine the pain you'd feel. Then, forget the situation and focus on the pain itself. Then try using the tool.

The Reversal of Desire

See the pain appear in front of you as a cloud. Scream silently at the cloud, "BRING IT ON!" Feel an intense desire for the pain to move you into the cloud.

Scream silently, "I LOVE PAIN!" as you keep moving forward. Go so deeply into the pain you're at one with it.

You will feel the cloud spit you out and close behind you. Say inwardly with conviction, "PAIN SETS ME FREE!" As you leave the cloud, feel yourself propelled forward into a realm of pure light.

The first two steps require activating your own will, but in the final step, you should feel carried by a force much bigger than you are: that's the Force of Forward Motion.

When you "bring on" the pain, make it as extreme as you can. What would it feel like if you got the very worst outcome? The audience boos your speech. Your spouse walks out on you in the middle of the confrontation. If you can master the worst, then anything less becomes easy. The more intense the pain—and the more aggressively you move into it—the more energy you'll create. Learn to go through the three steps quickly but intensely. Don't just do it once. Repeat the steps over and over until you feel you've thoroughly converted all the pain to energy. You can remember each step by the phrase that goes with it.

1. "Bring it on."
2. "I love pain."
3. "Pain sets me free."

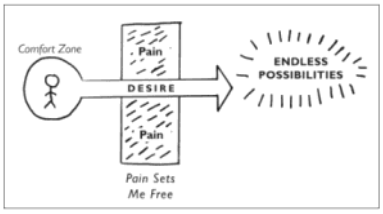
Just saying the three phrases will help you.

Now it should be clear why we call the tool the Reversal of Desire. You've taken your normal desire to avoid pain and reversed it into a desire to face it.

HOW THE REVERSAL OF DESIRE MASTERS PAIN

Using the tool regularly reveals the secret about pain that allows you to master it: pain is not absolute. *Your experience of pain changes relative to how you react to it.* When you move toward it, pain shrinks. When you move away from it, pain grows. If you flee from it, pain pursues you like a monster in a dream. If you confront the monster, it goes away. That's why desire is a crucial part of the tool. It keeps you moving toward pain. You're not desiring pain because you're masochistic; you're desiring pain so you can shrink it. When you become confident you can do this every time, you've mastered your fear of pain.

The diagram below illustrates how this process works. This time, when the figure leaves the Comfort Zone, he has a completely different mind-set. Not only isn't he trying to avoid pain, *he desires it*. It's this desire that puts him in motion; as I've said, when you're moving toward it, pain shrinks and becomes less intimidating. You can now move through it into an expanded world of endless possibility.



WHEN TO USE THE REVERSAL OF DESIRE

Just as important as learning a tool is knowing when to use it. We've found that this can't be left to chance. For every tool, there is a set of easily recognizable moments that call for its use. We call these "cues," just like a cue that triggers an actor to say his lines. Use the tool immediately every time you recognize a cue.

For the Reversal of Desire, the first cue is obvious—right before you're about to do something you want to avoid. Let's say you have to call someone who intimidates you, or you really need to get down to work, but you feel restless and distracted. At these moments, focus on the exact pain you'd feel if you began the action. Use the tool on that pain (multiple times if necessary) until you can feel the energy of the final step carrying you forward. Don't stop to think—let it lead you right into taking the action you were avoiding.

The second cue isn't as obvious because it occurs in your thoughts. We all share the same bad habit. When we have to do something we find extremely unpleasant, we start thinking about it rather than doing it: Why do I have to do it? I can't do it, I'll do it next week, etc. Thinking can't help you act in the face of pain; in fact, it usually makes you even more avoidant. The only way your thoughts can help you master pain is if they trigger you to use the Reversal of Desire. This is the second cue: each time you catch yourself thinking about the dreaded task, stop thinking and use the tool. This cue trains you to use the tool *right now*. No matter how far away the action is, the force you need to move forward can be generated only in the present. Each time you use this second cue, you're making a deposit in an invisible bank account; but you're depositing energy, not money—eventually you'll build up enough to act.

THE SECRET BENEFIT: TURNING PAIN INTO POWER

In truth, it wasn't luck at all. I've seen it over and over again; a patient puts some real effort into moving forward and all of a sudden, people and opportunities appear as if by magic to help him along the way. If these chance meetings and sudden opportunities aren't luck, what are they? The twentieth-century Scottish explorer W. H. Murray described it this way: "The moment one definitely commits oneself, then Providence moves too … raising in one's favor all manner of unforeseen incidents and meetings and material assistance, which no man could have dreamt would have come his way."

Providence is an antiquated term, but it's the right one. It connotes the support and guidance that come from something greater than yourself. What Murray was saying was that your forward motion puts you in sync with the greater movement of the universe—enabling you to avail yourself of the myriad opportunities it can provide you. This unforeseen assistance is one of the many benefits that higher forces can grant you. It's subject to the same rules we discussed earlier: you can't control these forces from the outside; you have to become like them in order to tap into their energy. It's easy to oversimplify this. A patient of mine toiled over many long nights and weekends to formulate a unique and creative proposal for his boss, but when he finally worked up the courage to submit the idea, his boss rejected it. "You told me that if I moved forward, the universe would help me," he complained.

This response illustrates how the modern mind typically misunderstands spiritual forces. It wants to make them predictably controllable. Yes, moving forward is a powerful way to connect to higher forces. But those forces are ultimately a mystery; they work in ways that are often beyond immediate understanding. The universe won't reward you like a trained seal every time you move forward. In fact, the naive belief that it would is simply another version of the Comfort Zone. As patients learn to work with higher forces, they encounter yet another mystery. They feel their powers growing when seemingly out of nowhere something bad happens. Often they're indignant, as if their connection to higher forces was supposed to magically immunize them from adversity. This reaction is a kind of spiritual immaturity. A true adult accepts that there's a fundamental difference between the goals we have for ourselves and the goals the universe has for us. In general, human beings want to succeed in the outer world—build a successful business, say, or find a life partner. In contrast, the universe doesn't care about our external success; its goal is to develop our *inner strength*. We care about what we achieve on the outside; *the universe is interested in who we are on the inside*.

There's a hidden, inner strength that you cannot find unless you push yourself through adversity. Friedrich Nietzsche, a daring thinker of the late nineteenth century, put it best in his famous aphorism: "Whatever does not kill me makes me stronger." His idea that adversity has a positive value was new. Nietzsche's statement makes it sound like adversity itself makes you stronger. It doesn't. Inner strength comes only to those who *move forward* in the face of adversity. That's impossible for a victim. His energy is wasted insisting it shouldn't have happened in the first place. He can't get that energy back until he accepts the event—no matter how painful it was. But *accepting bad things takes work*. This is where the Reversal of Desire comes in. It bypasses your opinion about *what should be* and gives you an active way to accept *what is*. This differs a bit from using it to prepare you for future pain. You use the tool the same way, but the target pain is in the past (even if it's just a few minutes in the past). In effect, you're training yourself to *desire what's already happened anyway*. The sooner and more frequently you use the tool when something bad happens, the faster you'll be able to recover. For some people it will be the first time in their lives they've faced adversity without feeling like a victim. With the Reversal of Desire, Nietzsche's idea becomes a reality.

At least it does with minor adversity—traffic delays or the copy machine breaking down. You begin to recover from these things faster than you thought possible; your frustration tolerance grows. But what

about when something really horrible happens? You lose your life savings, a child dies. Is it possible—is it even sane—to accept an event that destroys the fabric of your life?

Viktor Frankl amazing conclusion in his book *Man's Search for Meaning* was that even under indescribably harsh conditions—sleeplessness, starvation, and the ever-present threat of death—there was an opportunity to grow in inner strength. In fact, this was the one thing the Nazis *couldn't* take away from a prisoner. In the camps, the Nazis controlled everything—your possessions, the lives of your loved ones, and ultimately your own life. But the Nazis couldn't strip you of your determination to grow inwardly in whatever time you had left. As bleak and tenuous as life in the death camps was, Frankl asserted, it still presented "an opportunity and a challenge. One could make a victory of these experiences, turning life into an inner triumph, or one could ignore the challenge and simply vegetate." It was "just such an exceptionally difficult external situation which gives man the opportunity to grow spiritually beyond himself." This inner, spiritual strength at times enabled less hardy prisoners to survive the camps better than those who were physically more robust.

Frankl affirmed what we observed earlier—that whatever your goals are in the outside world, life has its own goals for you. If there is a conflict between these agendas, life will win. In his words, "It did not really matter what we expected from life, but rather what life expected from us." You had to find out what life was asking of you, even if it was simply to bear your suffering with dignity, sacrifice yourself for another, or not to give in to hopelessness for one more day—and then rise to that challenge.

FEAR AND COURAGE

The final thing the Reversal of Desire can do for you may be the most important of all—it allows you to develop courage. It always confused me that psychotherapy never addressed the need for courage directly—every patient I've ever had wanted more of it. But like the rest of us, therapists saw it as a kind of mythic power existing only in heroes who were beyond human fear—not a relevant topic for human psychology. Phil saw courage neither as a mythic power nor as a mystery. He defined it in a practical, human way that made it available to anyone. *Courage is the ability to act in the face of fear.* That this seems impossible to most people is because of the way we experience fear.

Fear is almost always linked to an image you have of something terrible happening in the future. If I speak up, I'll get fired. If I start my own business, I'll go bankrupt. The more you fixate on this future image, the more paralyzed you become—unable to act until you are certain the event won't happen. But that kind of certainty is impossible. It's hard to admit this; our whole culture is based on the lie that it's possible to be certain about the future. Go to the right school, eat the right foods, buy the right stocks, and your future is guaranteed. To develop courage, you have to give up this illusion of future certainty. This frees you to focus on the present—the only place you can find the courage to act. I'd read about "staying in the present" before I met Phil, but had always considered it a New Age cliché. I reconsidered when he taught me a concrete, step-by-step process for harnessing the power of the present.

The first step is to learn to experience fear without the mental image of the dreaded future event. Focus all your awareness on how the fear feels right now, in the present. When you've separated fear from what you're afraid of in the future, it becomes just another kind of pain you process with the Reversal of Desire.

The tool works the exact same way you've already been using it. You can substitute the word *fear* for *pain* or just remember that fear is a kind of pain. Either way, the energy the Reversal of Desire generates will allow you to take action. With practice, you'll realize it no longer matters what you're afraid of; every instance of fear can be dealt with the same way.

If it seems crazy to desire fear, remember you're not desiring the terrible event, just the feeling of fear it brings up. It's a paradox; only when you desire fear, will you be able to take action in its presence—which is what courage consists of.

But you can't hoard courage. Fear returns quickly, along with the image of the dreaded future event, taking you out of the present. If you're serious about living courageously, condition yourself to use the Reversal of Desire the moment you feel fear. You'll be amazed to find that when this becomes a reflex—and you don't think of the future at all—you'll act with more boldness than you've ever had in your life.

Phil described this as the process of fighting your way back to the present. Staying in the present isn't a state of mystical passivity, it's an *active* process that takes effort. The goal is to be comfortable enough with fear so that you can act. If you want superhuman fearlessness, you can always go to the movies.

OTHER USES OF THE REVERSAL OF DESIRE

The Reversal of Desire enables you to expand your professional and social circle. *We all know people we'd like to have a connection with but feel insecure about approaching. If you're honest with yourself, you question whether you're really on their level. It's easier to associate only with people who are no threat. This is really a form of avoidance that keeps you from living as fully as you can.*

The Reversal of Desire enables you to wield authority. *One of the hardest things about being a leader—whether you're the head of a department, an entire business, or even a family—is that you have to make decisions that make people unhappy. That's why they say "it's lonely at the top." An effective leader can tolerate the displeasure of others.*

The Reversal of Desire overcomes phobias. *A phobia is an irrational fear or dislike of something—like spiders or tight spaces. Its effect is to put certain parts of life out of your reach. Even in mild forms, it can interfere with your functioning at work and in relationships. The tool gives you the courage to put yourself in situations that your anxiety had placed off limits. Life can open up again.*

The Reversal of Desire allows you to develop skills that require a disciplined, long-term commitment. *The biggest difference between those who succeed and those who fail at any endeavor is their level of commitment. Most people would like to be committed. But in practice, commitment requires an endless series of small painful actions. When a person has no way to deal with that pain, his commitment falls apart.*

The Reversal of Desire gives you a new perspective on family dynamics that have been in place since childhood. *Try the following: Pick something that you got into the habit of avoiding as a child. What was the specific nature of the pain you were avoiding? Now, close your eyes, project yourself into that child, and use the Reversal of Desire on that pain. Imagine yourself as a child using that tool—automatically, every time you want to avoid, day after day, year after year. See if you get a sense of how your life might be different today—not the outward circumstances, but inside yourself. How does it feel different to be you?*

SUMMARY OF THE REVERSAL OF DESIRE

What the Tool Is For

Use the tool when you need to take an action you've been avoiding. We avoid doing the things that are most painful for us, preferring to live in a Comfort Zone that severely limits what we get out of life. The tool lets you act in the face of pain and helps you get your life moving again.

What You're Fighting Against

Pain avoidance is a powerful habit. You get immediate relief when you defer something painful. The penalty—helpless regret at a life you wasted—won't come until far in the future. This is why most people can't move forward and live life to the fullest.

Cues to Use the Tool

1. The first cue comes when you have to do something uncomfortable and you feel fear or resistance. Use the tool right before you act.
2. The second cue occurs whenever you *think* about doing something painful or difficult. If you use the tool every time you have these thoughts, you'll build a force that will allow you to act when the time comes.

The Tool in Brief

1. Focus on the pain you're avoiding; see it appear in front of you as a cloud. Silently scream, "Bring it on!" to demand the pain; you want it because it has great value.
2. Scream silently, "I love pain!" as you keep moving forward. Move so deeply into the pain you're at one with it.
3. Feel the cloud spit you out and close behind you. Say inwardly, "Pain sets me free!" As you leave the cloud, feel yourself propelled forward into a realm of pure light.

The Higher Force You're Using

The higher force that drives all of life expresses itself in relentless Forward Motion. The only way to connect to this force is to be in forward motion yourself. But to do that, you must face pain and be able to move past it. The Reversal of Desire lets you do this. Once the tool connects you to the Force of Forward Motion, the world is less intimidating, your energy is greater, and the future seems more hopeful.